It is abundantly clear that officially the Delhi government had only raised a demand of 590 MT of oxygen, which the Centre had allocated. Despite that, perhaps only to shift the blame at the mismanagement of the oxygen, Delhi government went to Court saying that an oxygen shortage in the city was due to the Centre's refusal to allocate oxygen which they had demanded. An ingenious plan which worked to their advantage as the media lapped up the story. Videos of desolate folks running from pillar to post craving for oxygen in addition to the victim card which the Delhi government played seemed to have done wonders to shift the blame on the Centre for the oxygen shortage in the national capital.

The Delhi High Court came down on the Centre and ordered it to supply 700 MT of oxygen to the Delhi government daily and warned of contempt proceedings if it failed to do so.

To slightly rewind the situation, officers from the Centre were in touch with officers from the state governments of high-risk states right from the first week of April. The Centre would ask for estimates of requirement of oxygen for the next five, 10 or 15 days and plan allocation accordingly. But the Delta virus was a new beast, something which the world had not previously seen. The requirement of oxygen grew exponentially, which even the states themselves had not accounted for. With the exponential increase, previous calculations came undone. This led to the worst of politics being played out. Questions were raised on oxygen allocation as if no mechanism of officers was ever in place on this issue. Human psychology is such that we often need someone we can blame. Would it be right to blame states for not anticipating the future requirement of oxygen? Would it be right to blame the Centre for planning according to the requirements sent by states? This was a once-in-a-century crisis caused by an extremely unpredictable virus.

Some even blamed the Centre for over-centralizing control in the pandemic and states having to request the Centre for its share of oxygen. But let us look at the counter scenario. Imagine if the Centre had said it would empower all states to manage their own oxygen. In such a hypothetical case, only some states would have managed to organize their own supplies while others would have had no source. Equitable or need-based distribution would be out of the question.

As soon as the allocation increased, Delhi came up with a new issue; that tankers carrying oxygen to Delhi were being blocked in UP and